

April

SPECIAL EVENTS

PHASES OF THE MOON

	Full Moon	New Moon
2008	April 20	April 6
2009	April 9	April 25
2010	April 28	April 14
2011	April 18	April 3
2012	April 6	April 21

THE PLANETS

2009: April 26 Mercury is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude 0.3.	2012: April 15 Saturn is at opposition, magnitude 0.2. At midnight, it is visible to the south from northern latitudes and to the north from southern latitudes.
2010: April 8 Mercury is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude 0.0.	2012: April 18 Mercury is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude 0.5.
2011: April 4 Saturn is at opposition, magnitude 0.4. At midnight, it is visible to the south from northern latitudes and to the north from southern latitudes.	

Opposition and elongation are explained on *page 14*

Leo remains high in the sky but now starts to make room for another zodiac constellation, Virgo. And a further mythical figure is making his presence felt. Boötes, the herdsman, is well placed for all observers. The third-largest constellation, Ursa Major, the Great Bear, is almost overhead for those in the northern hemisphere, while those observing from Earth's south find Crux prominently placed.

NORTHERN LATITUDES

Leo is high in the southwest sky, its distinctive shape easily picked out. The lion is looking toward the heads of the twins, Gemini, marked by the bright stars Castor and Pollux. The sky above and below is relatively barren. The long figure of Hydra, the water snake, straggles between Leo and the southern horizon. This is the largest constellation, but it is far from prominent. To the right, Virgo follows Leo across the sky. Its star Spica shines bright in the southeast. Above and to the east is Arcturus, the brightest star north of the celestial equator. At magnitude -0.05 , this red giant is the fourth-brightest star.

Looking north, Ursa Major is directly above Polaris, the Pole Star, and almost overhead. Seven stars that form the tail and rump of the bear make a saucepan shape in profile. Known as the Big Dipper, or the Plow, this is one of the most recognized star patterns in the northern hemisphere.

Cassiopeia is below, close to the horizon. To the northwest is the yellow-colored Capella, which, at magnitude 0.08, is the sixth-brightest star. It is the brightest and by far the most conspicuous star

in Auriga, the charioteer. To the east, Vega in Lyra heralds the arrival of the first of the summer constellations. Lyra is host to the Lyrids meteor shower, which peaks around April 21–22. A dozen or so meteors can be seen every hour radiating from a point near Vega.



Ursa Major and the Big Dipper

The seven stars in the Great Bear's tail and rump (top and center) form the Big Dipper. The second star in the tail is Mizar, which has a companion, Alcor. Both can be seen with binoculars or by anyone with good eyesight.

